

AI Readiness in Bangladesh: Enhancing AI to Reflect the Diversity of Bangladesh's Culture and Society

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is increasingly becoming a transformative force across all sectors, revolutionizing how we work, create, and interact. In Bangladesh, although AI readiness is gaining traction in different sectors, the challenges of cultural homogenization in the creative industries remain unaddressed. As Artificial Intelligence is not trained on culturally diverse datasets, these AI art tools frequently merge the diverse cultures, traditions, and histories of the region into a single narrative, overlooking the unique aspects that differentiate Bangladesh from its neighbors. As a result, Bangladesh's rich cultural heritage, societal values, artistic traditions, and diverse religious and ethnic communities—become diluted in AI-generated contents and often overshadowed by broader South Asian themes.

Through the National AI Art-a-thon competition, participants will create AI-generated artworks that showcase Bangladesh's rich and diverse culture, making their mark in an evolving global AI landscape. National AI Art-a-thon is Bangladesh's first nationwide AI-driven art competition. This unique competition brings together Bangladeshi art practitioners, art professionals, students (artists, creators, architects, graphic designers, content makers, and other visual artists), technologists, and AI enthusiasts in a dynamic and creative competition.

Categories for submission:

Category A: Professionals (individual or team of up to 3 members)

Category B: Students (individual or team of up to 3 members)

Note: Female participants are encouraged to apply.

Phase One (Virtual)

Phase One: Participants, either as individuals or teams, will work independently from their own workstations and submit their projects virtually. Upon completing registration ([registration link here](#)), participants must follow these steps to develop and submit their entries:

1. Select a Theme:

- Two themes are available for Phase One. Each participant or team must choose one theme per submission.
- Multiple submissions are allowed, but each requires a separate registration. Each registration will generate a unique registration number that must be included in the filenames of all submitted documents. Personal identities must not be disclosed in any submission materials.

2. Focus on the Themes:

- Participants must select one of the two provided themes for each submission. Detailed descriptions of the themes are included later in this document.

3. Generate AI Artwork:

- Participants are free to use any AI-based applications to generate images using their chosen prompts. Each participant or team must submit one final image that best represents the selected theme.

4. Deliverables:

Each participant or team must submit the following documents to complete their project entry for the competition:

a. AI-Generated Final Image/Artwork

- Filename: registration number_a.jpeg
- Format: JPEG only
- Size: A3
- Resolution: 300 dpi

b. Step-by-Step Prompt Documentation

- Filename: registration number_b.pdf
- Format: PDF
- Page Size: Letter
- ([click here](#) for the sample documentation)

c. Video Documentation of the Process

- Maximum Length: 2 minutes (fast-forwarding is allowed)

- Filename: registration number_c.mp4
- Format: MP4 or AVI
- Aspect Ratio: 16:9
- max limit: 2 minutes, process can be fast-forwarded, [click here](#) for the sample screen record video documentation

d. List of Applied AI Art Tools

- Provide a list of AI tools used (e.g., DALL-E, Midjourney, Stable Diffusion, Firefly) along with any additional digital tools such as Adobe Photoshop or Illustrator.
- Filename: registration number_d.pdf
- Format: PDF
- Page Size: Letter

e. Limitations of the AI applications you faced

- Can be written in Bengali or English.
- Filename: registration number_e.pdf
- Format: PDF

- Page Size: Letter

All required documents must be submitted via the competition website ([submission link here](#)).

Themes for Phase One:

1. Theme-1: “Time-Travelling: An Artathon Adventure into Urban Street Markets”

- Immerse yourself in the future as you delve into the buzzing street markets in Bangladesh. Let your creativity run wild as you imagine how these markets might appear a century from now. Use the following questions to ignite your inspiration:
- How will the essence of a bustling market change over the next century? How will the interfaces or displays evolve over this time? Could there be any correlations or contrasts in terms of the products offered? Will traditional materials adapt, or will they coexist with advanced, high-tech items?
- Imagine the market 100 years from now: Who will comprise the seller and buyer groups? Will they include women, ethnic minorities, or migrant workers? How might the interaction between vendors and customers from diverse backgrounds evolve? What societal and behavioral narratives will unfold as society transforms? Will inclusivity grow, or will it take on new forms?

- Will future marketplaces be dynamic enough to feature both traditional and modern commodities? How will they blend with the surrounding neighborhood? How might the cultural femininity and vibrant aesthetics be depicted through these bustling streets of cities like Dhaka and Chittagong?
- How do you envision the communal energy and resilience of these markets transforming in the next century? What future forms of collaboration and adaptation will emerge as urban environments and technology advance? How might the elements, colors, forms, and movement in your artwork reflect the evolving spirit of community within these spaces?

2. Theme-2: “Bangladesh’s Urban Jungle: An Artathon Adventure in Informal Housing”

Dive into the ever-changing world of informal urban housing in Bangladesh and express its vibrant complexity through your art. Let your work act as a window into these dynamic spaces and unleash your imagination to envision what these communities could look like 50 years from now. Use the questions below as creative sparks to bring the heart and soul of these informal urban landscapes to life!

- How might the informal fabric of urban housing transform in the coming years? What narratives could emerge from these changes?
- What might future households look like, and what elements will define them? How will the spaces in between these homes be represented?
- How can the roles of men and women within households be represented through your art? What about the role of young people in these neighborhoods? How might their contributions be highlighted visually in your work?

How can you capture the cultural and societal practices within informal settlements in your art? Do you think maintaining traditional concepts could be a better strategy for navigating current challenges? If so, how might you visually represent this? What contrasts or connections might emerge in the future between the built environment and its inhabitants? Will there be notable adaptations to improve living conditions? How can these ideas be reflected in your creative vision?

Note: The descriptions here have been provided as probes. Don't let them limit your imagination at all!

Phase Two (in-person):

1. 20 shortlisted teams (10 from Category A and 10 from Category B) will be brought together to a one day to ideate and complete the final task
2. Theme: NotunBangladesh/Bangladesh 2.0 (specifications will be announced later)
3. Shortlisted participants will get 120 minutes for image creation and an additional 60 minutes for documentation. Deliverables and submission formats are similar to Phase One.
4. Experts and mentors will be available in the final phase to support the participants
5. Participants will present their art/images to the judges of the competition

Prize money & Opportunities:

1. In total four teams (2 teams from Category A & 2 from Category B) will be finalists and they will get a total of 6 lacs prize money
2. The shortlisted arts will be showcased through an exhibition that will engage the wider public, including artists, educators, technologists, and policymakers, and create an awareness of AI's potential to express local identity and creativity

Contact: artathonbd@gmail.com